

invested in this to make me a millionaire," he adds. The fact that the photographers he's invested in are selling at three times what they were two years ago, is a validation of his investment. Datta is not the only one, urban India is suddenly waking up to the possibility of photographs occupying prime spaces hitherto reserved for paintings; grand corridors and opulent landings of the well-heeled where photographs now share space with canvases, paper works and sculptures.

The biggest thing going for photographs in India at the moment is their pricing. With prices of paintings having gone through the roof, the art market has a void that was dying to be filled. For prices ranging between Rs 10,000 and Rs 5 lakh, one can even buy doyens like the late Raghubir Singh. "Photography is still hugely undervalued in the scheme of art, in terms of comparison to sculpture and painting," says Joshua Holdeman, International director of photography at Christie's auction house as quoted in *Fortune*. "You can buy one of the icons of art history in the photography genre for the same price as a third rate Renoir sketch," he adds.

The other remarkable change in the market has been in terms of space itself. It has become more lucrative for galleries to regularly show photographs. "As recently as four years ago photographers used to get dates for a

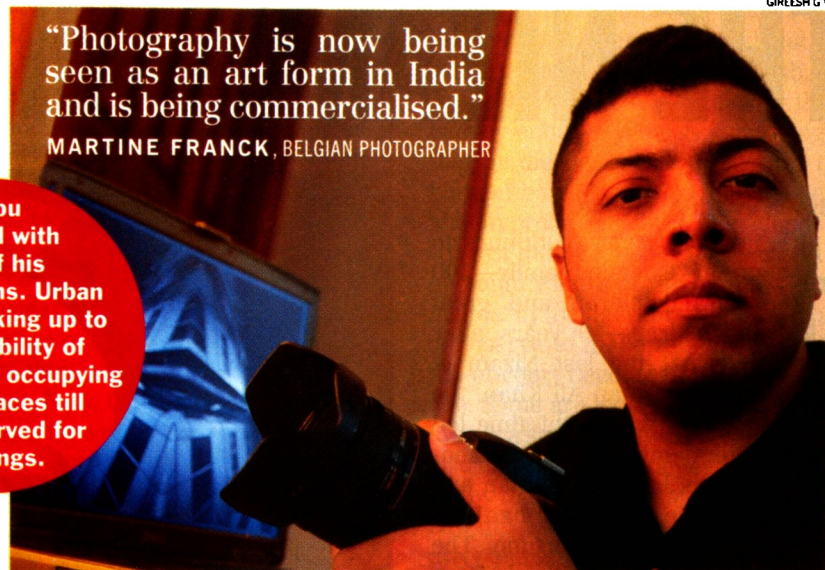
few days in the monsoons when no one would come to the galleries," says leading photographer Amit Mehra whose recent exhibition opened on the same day as the final of the Twenty20 World Cup match. "I was quite resigned and didn't expect too many people," says Mehra, who was taken aback by the attendance of over 500 people, comprising private collectors, corporate houses, banks and others. "Four years ago I would sell at about Rs 15,000 or Rs 20,000, today the prints (10 editions) fetch about a lakh each," he adds.

Further obliterating the barrier between paintings and photography is Tasveer—India's first gallery for photographs, owned and run by art collector

Abhishek Poddar, in Bangalore, Shalini Gupta in Delhi and Seagull in Kolkata. With photographs fetching record prices abroad in auctions at both Sotheby's and Christie's in 2006, the photograph market abroad has sky-rocketed. It is only a matter of time before auction houses in India like Osians enter the photography market. Other galleries showing cutting-edge work are Bodhi in both Delhi and Mumbai, the National Gallery of Modern Art, Sumukha in Bangalore, Mathius and Foss, and Priyashree in Mumbai, and Vadhera Art Gallery.

That the publishing industry reaps the benefits goes without saying.

With a series of books on photography, photographers and coffee table books, the future looks bright. Leading from the front is Hemant Mehta of India Pictures. "We are still a photo bank, but our future projects include publishing and our aim will be to promote Indian photography and photographers," he says. The series will start with *King, Commoner, Citizen*—monographs by photojournalist Prashant Panjiar. "Now many more Indian photographers' work have become visible to the 'outside world' through exhibitions, books, art fairs, museums or on the Internet and not just in the press or in family albums," says Franck summing up the new wave in Indian photography. ■



"Photography is now being seen as an art form in India and is being commercialised."

MARTINE FRANCK, BELGIAN PHOTOGRAPHER

Shibu Arakkal with one of his photographs. Urban India is waking up to the possibility of photographs occupying prime spaces till now reserved for paintings.

ISHAN TANKHA

"You can buy one of the icons of photography for the same price as a third rate Renoir sketch."

JOSHUA HOLDEMAN, International director of photography at Christie's



Dayanita Singh at one of her exhibitions. Photographs sell between Rs 10,000 and Rs 5 lakh, where one can even buy doyens like the late Raghubir Singh.